



In the firing line: UP Warriorz captain Alyssa Healy tackled a pitch invader during her team's seven-wicket victory over the Mumbai Indians in Bengaluru. PTI

Giants and Warriorz are the two franchises yet to gain experience of hosting games in the cities that won the bids. Adesara believes it is too soon for an IPL-like home-and-away format in the WPL.

"It's equally important for all teams to get matches back to the cities they've built their franchises around. With five teams, a home-and-away season becomes a big financial challenge early on. As the league grows, we might head in this direction with more certainty. Ahmedabad is more than ready to host the league in the best stadiums in the world," he says.

Building a fanbase is challenging, whether you're an existing IPL franchise branching out in the WPL or a fresh entity.

Merchandising has been a key aspect of conversations in business boardrooms for these franchises, and each one is trying to strike a balance between commercial upswing and

value for the consumer.

"There were good lessons for us from the experience of the World Cup. Adidas cracked it in terms of the product and price point. We've got Puma as a partner. We are the first Indian franchise to launch its jersey with the women's team. They are also a part of our Kabaddi franchise. Brands are beginning to see value," Singh explains.

"From here, we need to look at strategies to promote sales. Everyone is buying on Instagram today, so maybe that's an area for us to maximise. I am an eternal optimist. I won't say sports merchandise won't work in India. Decathlon, Puma, and others have shown the way and proved that the Indian customer is extremely value conscious, and if we provide a good product, there's no reason why it won't sell."

However, he believes there are other areas to prioritise, one of which is the fan experience at stadiums, particularly for women. Incidentally, apparel brand Puma released a film during the WPL that revealed that only 18 per cent of women who watch men's cricket watch women's games. Singh explains that, as JSW

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With the victory in the final, RCB finally registered its first win against Delhi Capitals. It has lost all four previous meetings against this side. Mumbai Indians' 4-0 head-to-head record against Gujarat Giants is the only unbeaten match-up left in the tournament.

RCB's spinners claimed nine out of the 10 DC wickets in the final, this is the most taken by a team's spinners in a WPL game bettering the eight taken by UP Warriorz against RCB in season one.

Big collapse: After a comfortable 64/0 in seven overs, Delhi Capitals crumbled, losing 10 wickets for just 49 runs in 11.3 overs in the final.

Smriti Mandhana has been dismissed nine times by off spinners in WPL history, this is the most for any batter (five dismissals in WPL 2023, four times in the 2024 edition)

addressed this with football and Bengaluru FC's stadium experience for women fans at the Sree Kanteerava Stadium, the WPL is not far behind.

"The Indian stadium experience needs a fresh outlook. My mom and sister don't like coming to the stadium to watch a game as much. We rave about experiences of heading to an EPL match or other sports abroad. So, we want to do that here.

"With BFC, we have a healthy number of female supporters and have taken small steps to ensure their match-viewing comfort and safety are kept in mind, and that has been well received. Given that we stand at the centre of multiple sporting franchises, we have the unique opportunity to make a difference," he said.